VI—Bloodthirsty Sword

> ‘With the help of our bloodthirsty sword we have erased the signs of infidelity from their minds and have destroyed temples in those places and also all over Hindustan.’
>
> – *Fathnama* proclaiming Akbar’s victory over Chittorgarh
>
> ‘The words of kings resemble pearls. They are not fit pendants to every ear.’
>
> – Akbar, Happy Sayings, *Ain-i-Akbari*

The village near which the Uzbek siblings and their revolt died was renamed Fatehpur, city of victory. It is one of the pitfalls of writing history that facts – and certainly names – seldom arrange themselves for narrative convenience. There are at least three ‘Muzaffars’, for example, crowding the annals of Akbar’s reign. There are also, it turns out, two ‘Fatehpurs’. This one, a village near Allahabad that never attained the glory of the city of stone that Akbar would build near Agra, might not have been worth the confusion of mentioning at all, if the grandness of its title, thrust upon an obscure hamlet, did not suggest how important this win was for Akbar, how close Ali Quli came to plunging Akbar’s realm into chaos.

Far from the Uzbeks’ eastern stronghold, on the gossiping streets of Agra, writes Badauni, ‘news-mongers, and especially drug and opium takers, used every day . . . to spread gloomy reports’.[1] Nizamuddin the historian was in the city at the time, an eyewitness to how ‘designing men spread disastrous news’.[2] Such rumours were dangerous; they could topple thrones. Nizamuddin decided to float his own counter-story on the streets. ‘Let us say,’ he told a friend, ‘that news has come that they are bringing in the heads of [Ali Quli] and Bahadur Khan.’

Abul Fazl tells a similar tale, featuring Munim Khan, left behind as governor of Agra, and Abul Fazl’s father, the scholar and theologian Shaikh Mubarak. Munim, too, was troubled by ‘empty-brained and talkative’ rumour-mongers, and came to Shaikh Mubarak ‘for moral support’. The shaikh offered to undertake a Sufi meditation that evening, and had a comforting vision; the very same, in fact, as Nizamuddin’s strategic rumour.[3]